I didn’t feel like crying. I’m not sure it felt like the time to shake hands either, but I did. I left feeling that nothing had been resolved; that nothing had really changed. The next morning at training, though, it felt like something had. The manager was completely different, or seemed to be: positive, encouraging, friendly even. For a while, it was great. It seemed as if the meeting had, after all, done the trick. It was all I needed to lift me out of the gloom I’d sensed myself slipping into. Not getting it in the neck every other day meant I could enjoy training and playing again like I hadn’t for weeks. It felt like me and the boss had found our way past something: the tension that had been between us since the broken rib and my visit to Buckingham Palace.

I was wrong. In fact, it was the calm before the storm.

The Sunday before I went off to join up with England, we played Manchester City at home. Earlier in the season, we’d lost the game 3–1 at Maine Road. I hadn’t played, so that couldn’t have been my fault. Just as well. The next day, Gary Neville told me that, in the dressing room, the manager had been as angry as he’d ever seen him after a game. The result at Old Trafford wasn’t much better. We conceded a late goal and drew 1–1. The manager picked me out for criticism in the dressing room afterwards, saying I’d given the ball away too often. I could only think of a couple of passes that had gone astray. I didn’t rise to it, I just sat and let him have his say, but then, during the week, regretted that I hadn’t. If I’d stuck up for myself that afternoon rather than waiting until after our next home game, perhaps things wouldn’t have blown up in our faces the way they did.

People say a change is as good as a rest. The week England lost 3–1 to Australia at Upton Park, it certainly wasn’t. The senior side played the first half and we never really got going: it was a strange atmosphere, knowing that after 45 minutes the young players were going to come on instead, a completely different team. The Australians, most of whom play their club soccer in England, were really up for it and they were worth their two-goal lead at half-time. I was really angry about what was happening. As soon as we got back to the dressing room, I asked Sven if I could play for at least part of the second half as well. I thought we owed it to the England supporters and to ourselves to try and put the situation right. He said no, that the arrangements had been made and so it wasn’t a good idea. This was an exhibition and a chance for him to have a look at players like seventeen-year-old Wayne Rooney.

If you think about the Euro 2004 qualifier against Turkey at the Stadium of Light later in the season and the difference Wayne made in that game, I